



hilo

Brand Guidelines

Revised March 2026

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Introduction

Welcome to the Hilo Brand Guide. This document is a practical guide to the purpose, promise, and personality behind Hilo. It introduces the core principles that shape how the brand speaks, looks, and behaves.

Inside, you'll find the thinking that informs our storytelling, design, partnerships, and decision-making. Use it to keep work aligned, intentional, and true to what Hilo stands for.

Think of this as a compass, not a rulebook. Reference it often. Use your judgment. Build forward with clarity.

01 ——— Brand Strategy



Purpose

Our timeless north star and why we exist beyond what we do. Use this as a filter for decision-making, storytelling, and alignment across ventures.

To weave equity into the fabric of entrepreneurship.

Hilo exists to strengthen the threads that tie businesses, communities, and systems together, helping purpose-driven entrepreneurs and partners create structures that last and uplift everyone connected to them.

Brand Pillars

Our core strengths that prove how we deliver on our promise. Apply these pillars as criteria for decision-making and execution, ensuring every initiative reflects Hilo’s core strengths.

We connect the threads that make business work
Hilo strengthens the connection between doing good and doing business. We turn individual efforts into shared progress by providing the tools, structure, and support entrepreneurs, partners, and funders need to grow lasting impact together.

01 — Connection that moves us forward

We turn relationships into momentum, linking entrepreneurs, partners, and resources so everyone grows stronger together.

02 — Equity in action

We turn relationships into momentum, linking entrepreneurs, partners, and resources so everyone grows stronger together.

03 — Designed to last, ready to scale

We co-create solutions alongside the people who will use them, ensuring our resources and structure reflects real needs.

Tone and Voice

How our brand speaks; the qualities that make our communication distinct and human. Use this to shape all written communication so our voice feels consistent and true to who we are.

Optimistic, welcoming, earnest. Our language is as inclusive and diverse as the entrepreneurs and communities we serve. We speak in accessible language that meets people where they are and helps them get where they aspire to be.

Do:

- Use integrative, communal language that is rooted in real experience
- Lead with purpose, say things simply and with conviction
- Acknowledge challenges without dwelling in them; encourage and remind of possibilities
- Celebrate progress, effort, and shared wins

Don't:

- Use jargon, academic language, or complex terms that complicate communication
- Over-promise or use language that feels performative
- Sound corporate, institutional, transactional, or detached
- Position Hilo as the hero; keep the spotlight on entrepreneurs and partners

Tone and Voice

Equity Is Currency

Equity grows when people move together.
We’re in the business of connecting the dots.

Equity is not an add-on. It’s what makes
progress possible.

Equity shows up in how we connect people,
how we share knowledge,
and how we build systems together.

It turns lived experience into real support
and individual effort into shared momentum.

We believe doing good and doing business can grow side by side.
When equity is built into the work, trust grows, opportunity
expands, and businesses are better positioned to last.

This is what it means to move forward together.

Brand Framework

Our Purpose

To weave equity into the fabric of entrepreneurship. Hilo exists to strengthen the threads that tie businesses, communities, and systems together, helping purpose-driven entrepreneurs and partners create structures that last and uplift everyone connected to them.

Who we serve:

Entrepreneurs shaping a more equitable economy. We support entrepreneurs and small business owners across sectors, helping them grow, connect, and build the structures that make opportunity more accessible to their communities.

Value proposition:

We connect the threads that make business work. Hilo strengthens the connection between doing good and doing business. We turn individual efforts into shared progress by providing the tools, structure, and support entrepreneurs, partners, and funders need to grow lasting impact together.

Brand pillars:

Connection that moves us forward	Equity in action	Designed to last, ready to scale
We turn relationships into momentum, linking entrepreneurs, partners, and resources so everyone grows stronger together.	We turn relationships into momentum, linking entrepreneurs, partners, and resources so everyone grows stronger together.	We co-create solutions alongside the people who will use them, ensuring our resources and structure reflects real needs.

Tone and Voice:

Optimistic, welcoming, earnest. We speak like the community we serve: thoughtful, collaborative, and confident in purpose.

02 — Brand Positioning



Value Proposition

The promise we make to entrepreneurs, funders and partners, and how we fulfill it. Use this to shape how we communicate our offerings and design our programs. It ensures our messaging, materials, and partnerships consistently reflect the value we deliver.

We connect the threads that make business work

Hilo strengthens the connection between doing good and doing business. We turn individual efforts into shared progress by providing the tools, structure, and support entrepreneurs, partners, and funders need to grow lasting impact together.

What the need:

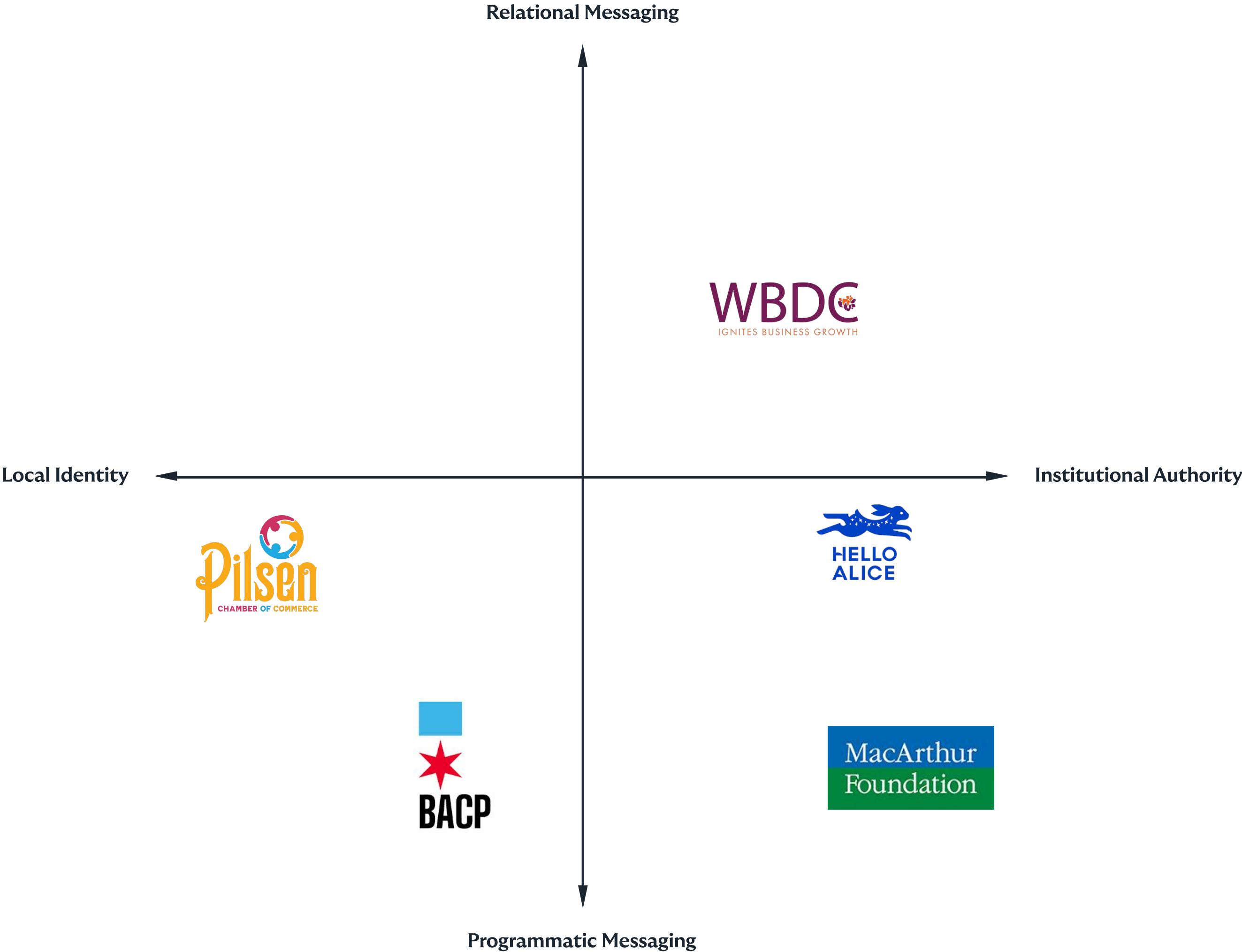
- Clear guidance through moments of uncertainty
- Support structures that reduce isolation and open doors to resources
- Tools and networks that help them stabilize, grow, and eventually scale

What drives them:

- Creating businesses that strengthen their communities
- Turning their craft and personal story into economic power
- Owning something that reflects who they are, their values, identity, and vision

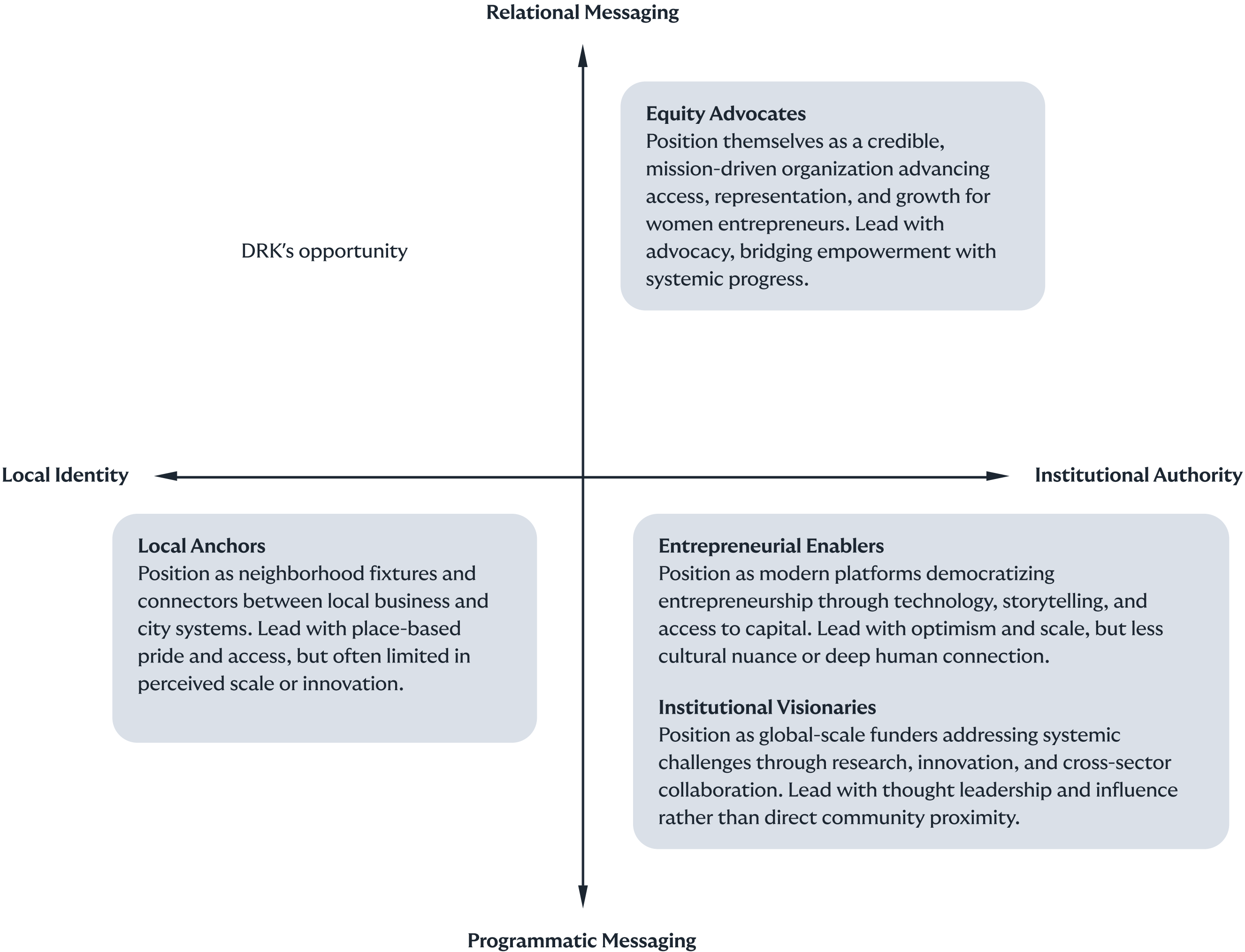
Peer Lanscape Context

Across the ecosystem, many share our mission but few share our model.

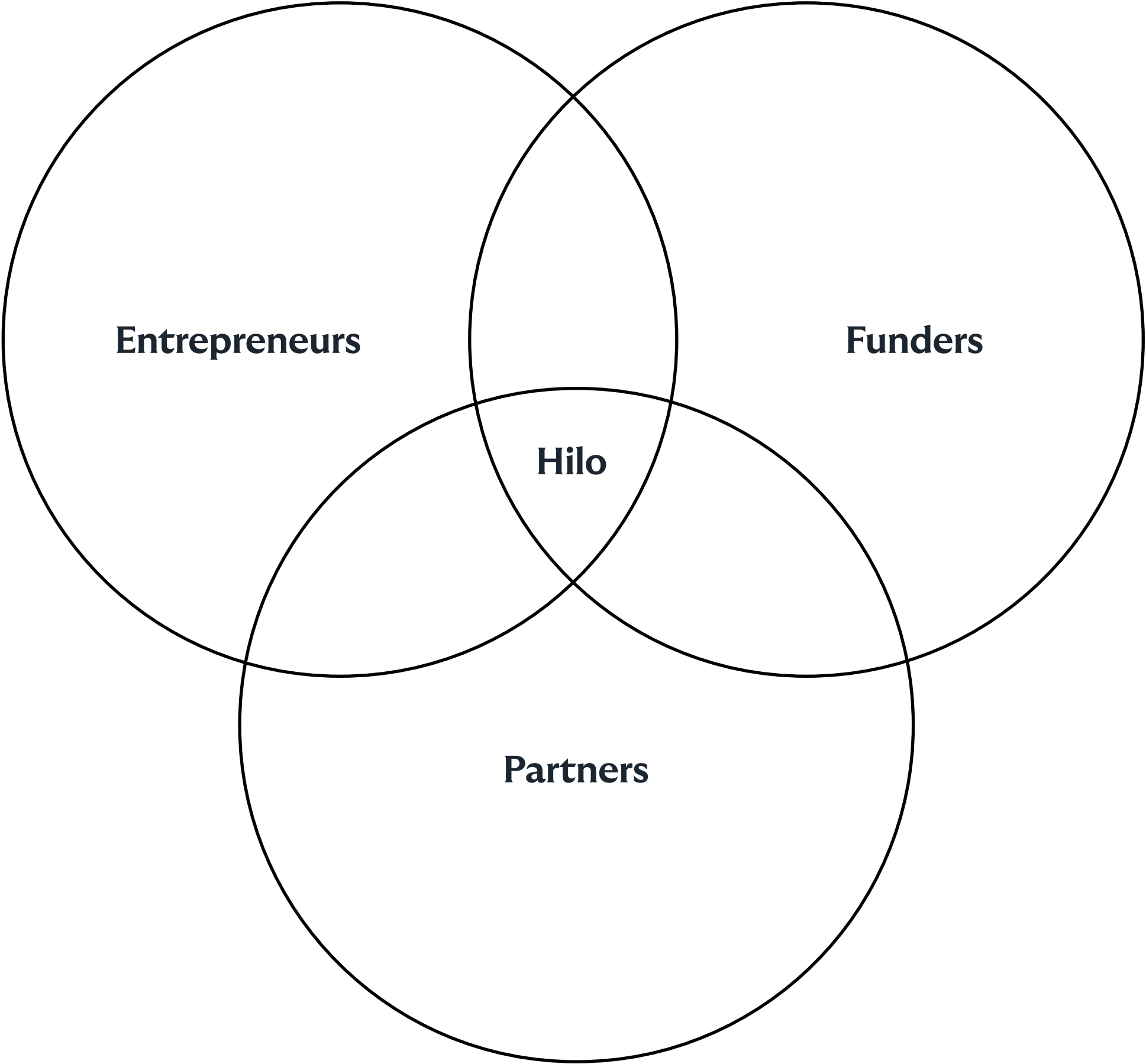


Peer Lanscape Context

Few connect scale with human experience the way DRK does.



Our Audience



Our Audience Entrepreneurs

The people and partners at the heart of our mission. Use this as a guide for audience-specific messaging, outreach, programming, and partnership strategy. This ensures that every touchpoint speaks directly to the needs and realities of those we serve.

Entrepreneurs shaping a more equitable economy. We support purpose-driven entrepreneurs across industries, helping them grow, connect, and move through challenges with guidance, shared structures, and resources that make opportunity accessible to all.

What the need:

- Clear guidance through moments of uncertainty
- Support structures that reduce isolation and open doors to resources
- Tools and networks that help them stabilize, grow, and eventually scale

What drives them:

- Creating businesses that strengthen their communities
- Turning their craft and personal story into economic power
- Owning something that reflects who they are, their values, identity, and vision

Our Audience Funders

Funders who invest in entrepreneurs and their support systems. They look for partners who are trusted in community, operate with transparency, and can turn resources into measurable, meaningful impact.

What the need:

- Clear visibility into how investments strengthen entrepreneurs and their support systems
- Partners who are transparent, trusted, and strong in execution
- Models that turn funding into durable growth, not short-term activity
- Proof of momentum and impact

What drives them:

- Investing in work that delivers real, measurable results, not just activity
- Being associated with meaningful change that strengthens communities
- Backing partners who reflect their values and protect their reputational risk
- Supporting solutions that can scale and endure beyond individual grants

Our Audience

Partners

Partners are the connective tissue that makes this work stronger and more visible. They bring expertise, infrastructure, and reach, working alongside us to amplify collective impact in service of entrepreneurs.

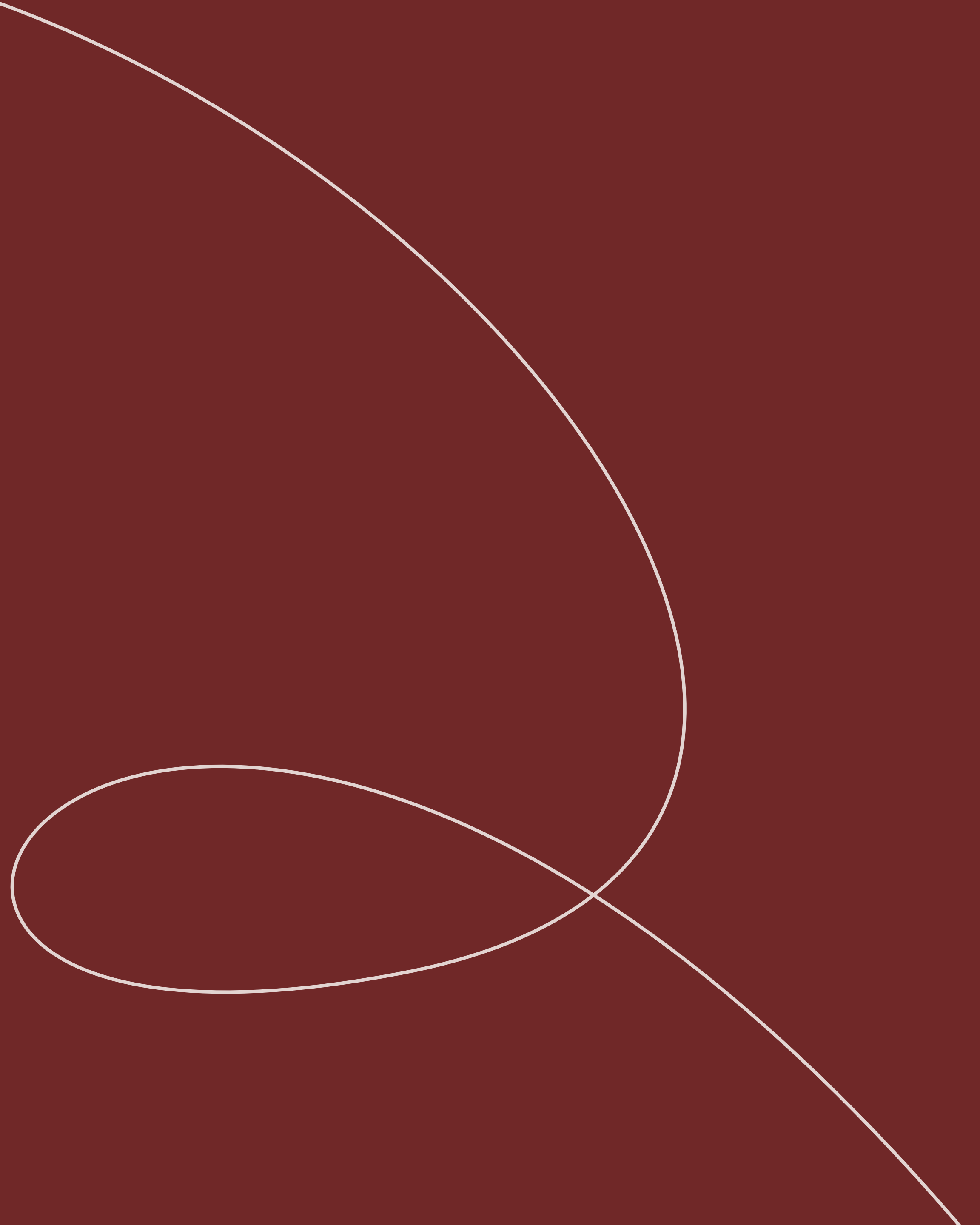
What the need:

- Clear understanding of how their work fits into a shared system
- Visibility into roles, responsibilities, and points of coordination
- Strong collaboration that reduces duplication and inefficiency
- Trusted partners who operate with transparency and follow-through

What drives them:

- Creating greater impact through collaboration, not siloed efforts
- Contributing specialized strengths to a broader, shared mission
- Building durable partnerships rooted in shared purpose and trust

03 — Visual Language



Logo

The Hilo logo builds on the concept of the thread. Based on GT Ultra, the four letters are connected through custom bottom ligatures, symbolizing togetherness and strength. Adhering to these guidelines ensures the logo is used correctly and consistently across all applications.

- 01

Clear space ensures the logo has room to breathe when used alongside other logos or visual elements. This clear space is defined by the outer and vertical strokes of the “i” and “l.”
- 02

The logo should not be scaled below 64px in printed materials to maintain its integrity.

01



Clear Space

02

hilo

Minimum print size : 64px

Logo

The Hilo logo includes a monogram that may be used as a shorthand version of the brand mark. This monogram is intended for use in avatars and other applications where the full logo is not required or where a more expressive brand presence is appropriate.

- 01

The H monogram captures the essence of the full wordmark by incorporating a subtle thread extension at the end of the “H.”
- 02

Designed to take advantage of horizontal space, the H thread monogram unspools the letterform, visually tying the thread motif and the Hilo logo system together.

01

H monogram



02

H thread monogram



End Card

The Hilo endcard animation exists as a sign off. It’s a visual punctuation mark to unify Hilo’s video content across platforms.

Use at the end of

- Instagram Reels
- Instagram Grid Videos
- Stories
- Any video content tied to Hilo

Formats

Vertical (9:16)

For Reels, Stories, Shorts, and mobile-first content.

Horizontal (16:9)

For grid videos, presentations, websites, or longer-form edits.

Colorways

- Off White on Dark Navy → Primary
- Dark Navy on Off White → Secondary
- Dark navy on Burnt Orange → High energy content
- White on Black → When color is not an option (ie. sponsor slides)

Colorways

- Don’t resize or distort the logo
- Don’t use as an intro
- Don’t add text, tags, or calls-to-action on top
- Don’t remix or add filters to the animation



Typography

GT Ultra is Hilo’s primary workhorse typeface. It blends academic and social design to establish a sense of heritage and reinforce a trustworthy, goal-oriented brand presence. Regular and Bold are the primary weights and should be used consistently and in complementary ways across all applications.

GT Ultra Median

Regular

Aa Bb Cc Dd Ee Ff Gg Hh
Ii Jj Kk Ll Mm Nn Oo Pp
0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

Bold

**Aa Bb Cc Dd Ee Ff Gg Hh
Ii Jj Kk Ll Mm Nn Oo Pp
0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9**

Aa

Typography Hierarchy

The Hilo type hierarchy is intentionally simple, contributing to an elegant and timeless feel. All typography is set in GT Ultra, using Regular and Bold weights to differentiate content.

- Headlines are set at 2× the size of the body copy.
- Subheadlines are set at the same size as body copy, using the Bold weight.
- Buttons are always set in sentence case and use the Regular weight.

x2

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet

x1 **Bold**

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet

x1

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consectetur adipiscing elit. Quisque faucibus ex sapien vitae pellentesque sem placerat. In id cursus mi pretium tellus dui convallis. Tempus leo eu aenean sed diam urna tempor.

x1

Learn More

Color

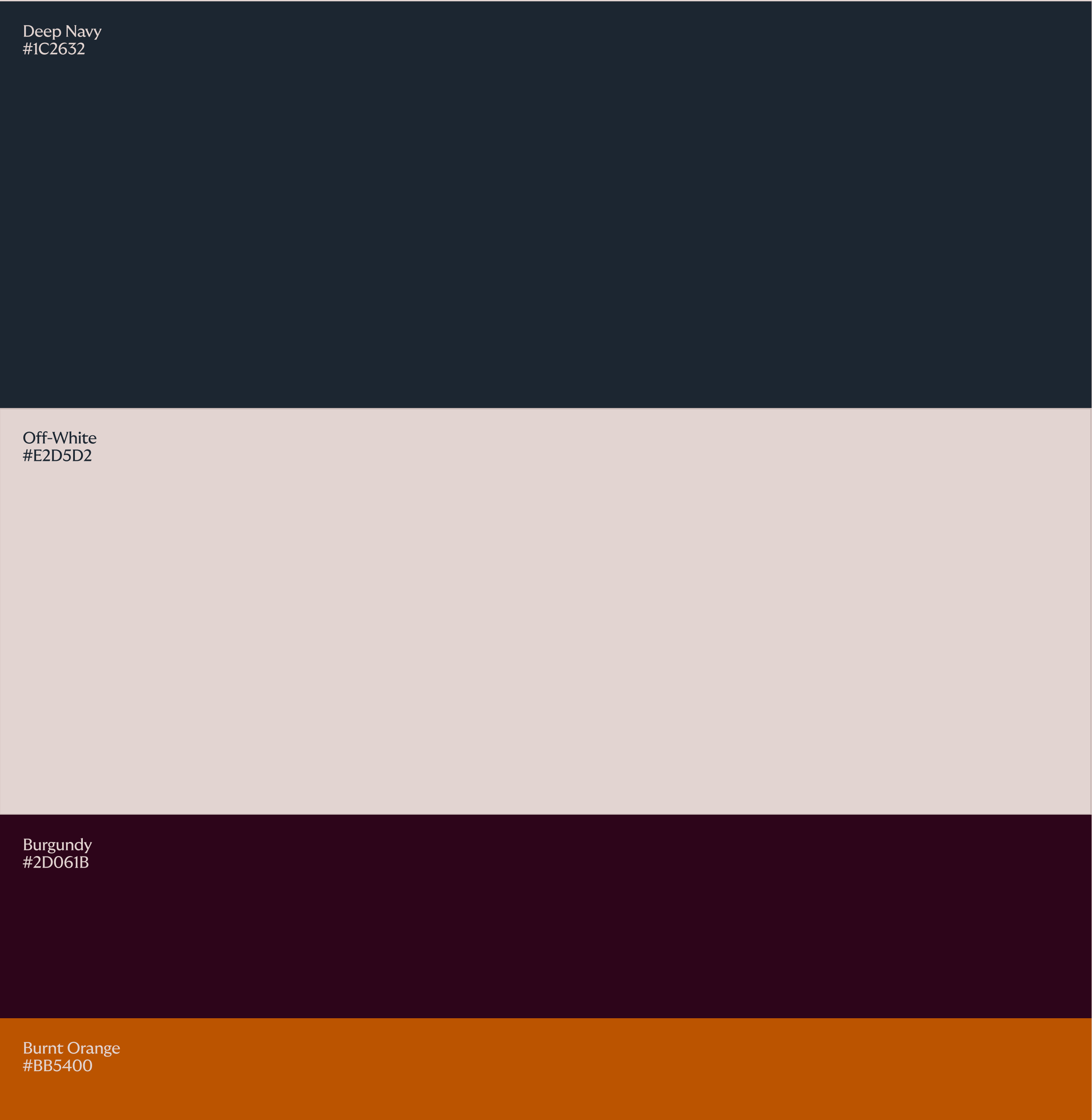
Color plays a critical role in the Hilo visual system. Inspired by academia and government programs, the palette is designed to communicate trust and confidence.

Deep Navy — Primary brand color. Used for dark backgrounds and foundational layouts.

Off-white — Primary light color. Used to create contrast and balance against darker elements.

Burgundy — Secondary color. May be used as an alternative to Navy but should be used sparingly.

Orange — Accent color. Reserved for calls to action, highlights, and moments requiring emphasis.



Logo and Text Color Combinations

For maximum legibility, use the approved color combinations when applying the logo or placing text on colored backgrounds. Always ensure sufficient contrast to maintain clarity and accessibility.



Thread

The thread is a core visual device used to connect and unify elements across the Hilo brand. Multiple thread shapes are available and may be used across a variety of applications.

Two thread styles are supported: solid and dotted. These styles may be used to introduce visual variety within layouts.

When used as a background element, the thread should be tightly cropped and positioned in a balanced manner that does not distract from the primary content. When connecting text or images, the thread must not overlap letterforms or faces. Always use contrasting colors to ensure the thread remains clearly visible.



Thread

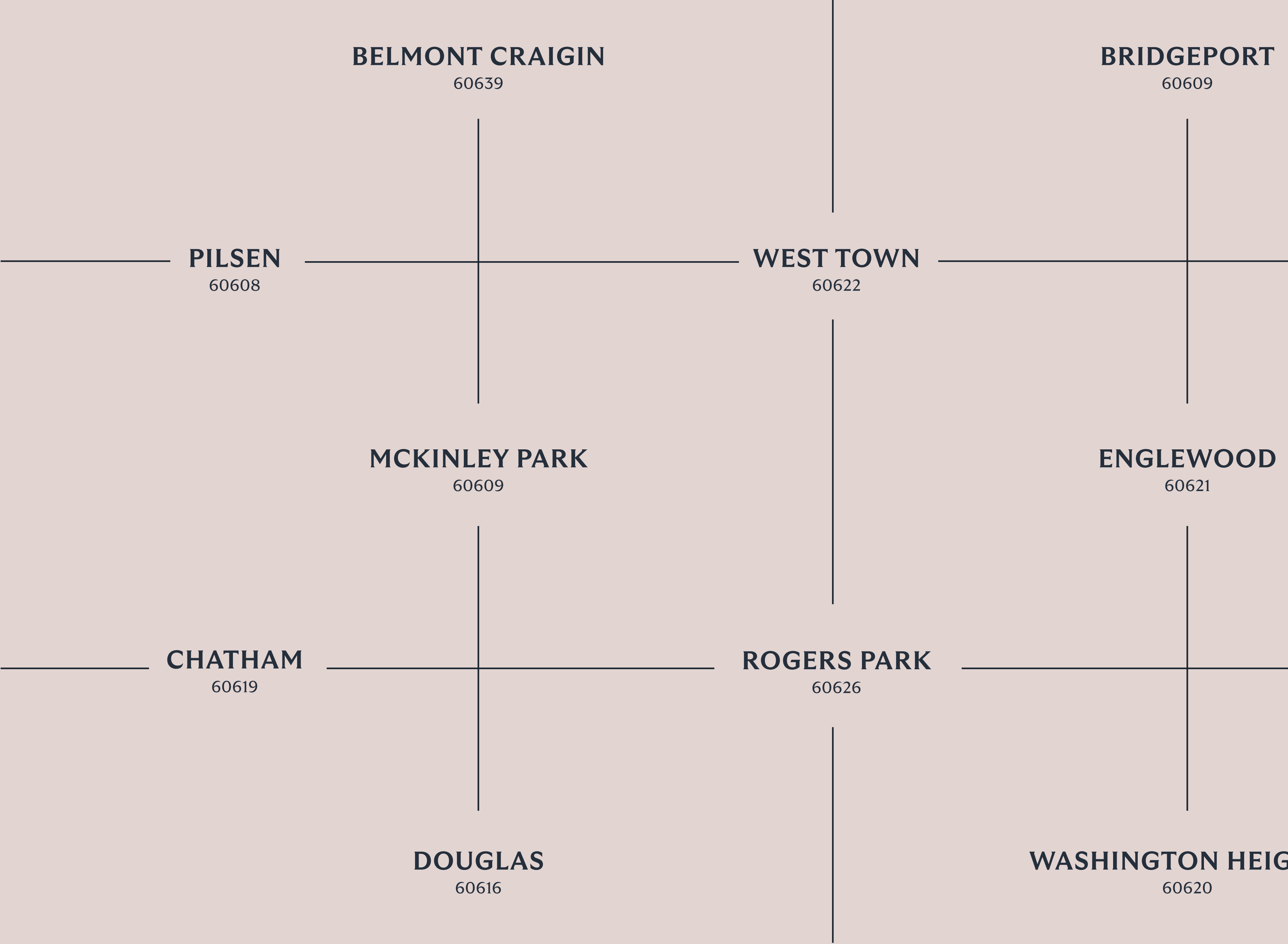
Color Combinations

For maximum legibility, use the approved color combinations when applying the thread on colored backgrounds. Always ensure sufficient contrast to maintain clarity and accessibility.



Thread

Threads can also act more structured and can act as a grid system.



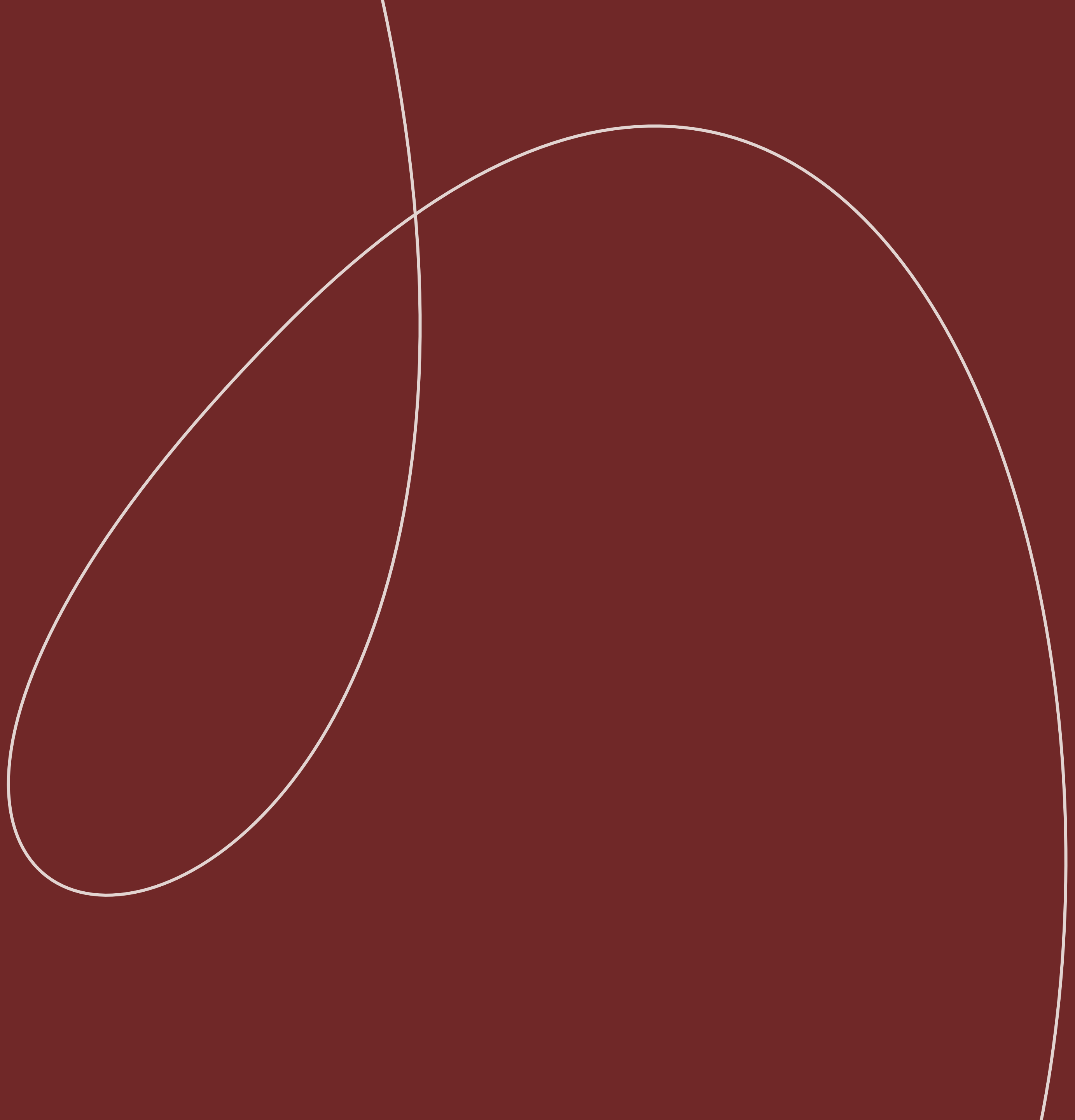
Photography

It is important to highlight and showcase the entrepreneurs that we work with everyday. When photographing them or looking for things to capture consider:

- Capture portraits in natural light whenever possible.
- Photograph subjects within their environment, treating the business and its location as key elements of the story.
- Focus on people at work, capturing a mix of detail close-up shots and wider contextual shots.
- Color is important—lean into warmer tones to create a welcoming, human feel.



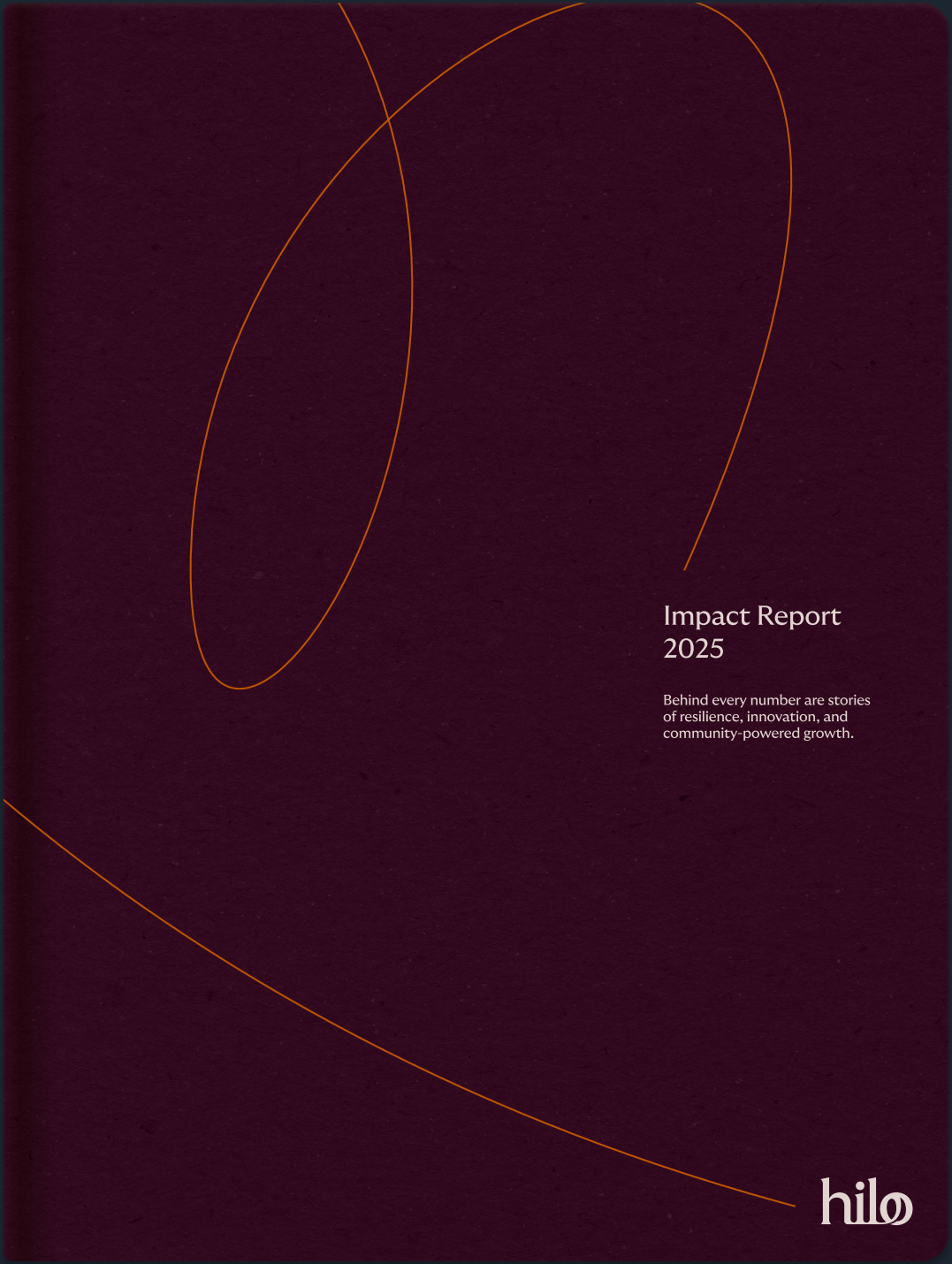
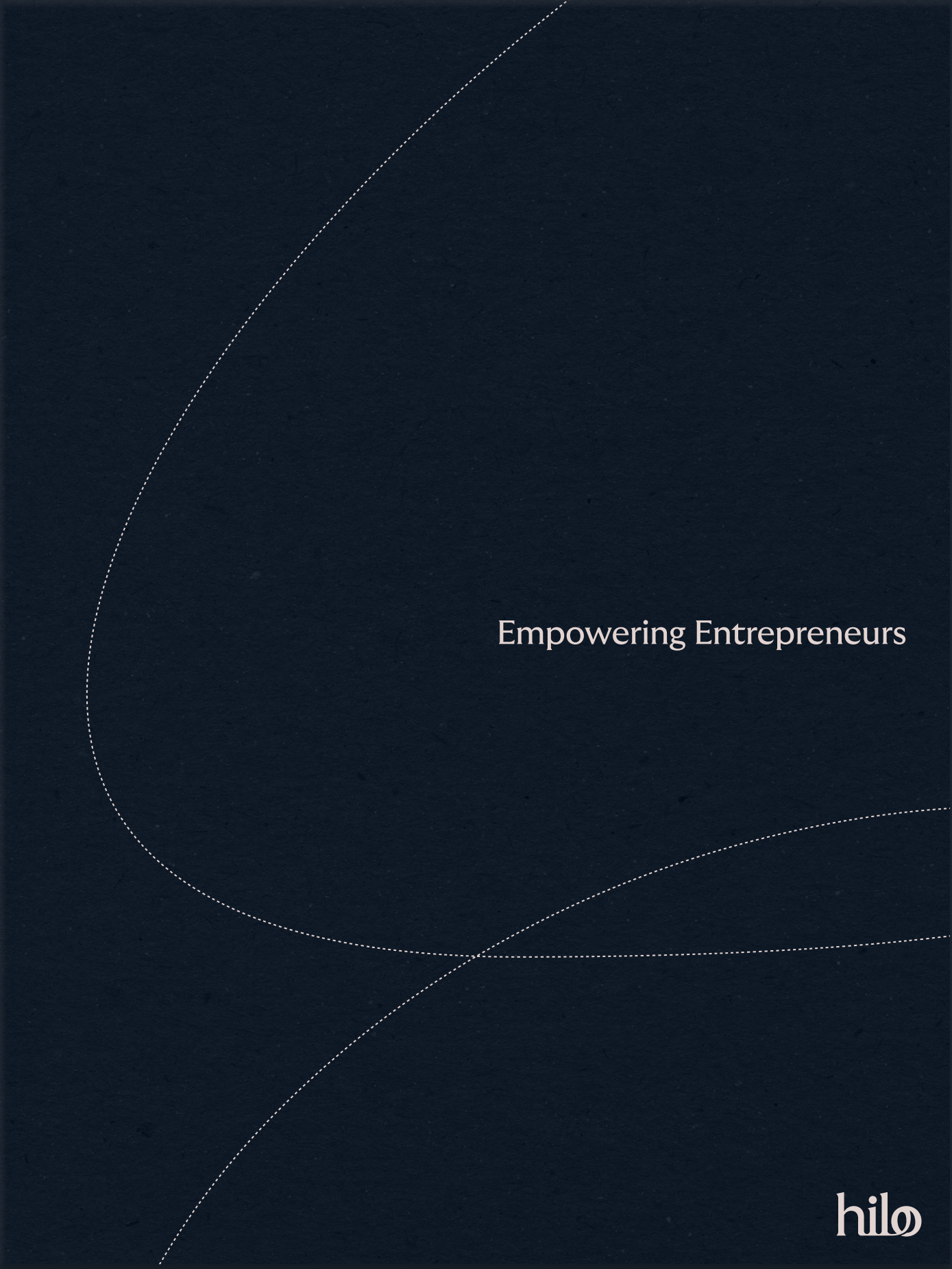
04 — Applications



Business cards



Folder and Notebook



Impact Report

2025
Key Metrics

Behind every number are stories of resilience, innovation, and community-powered growth.



Success Story

Selena grew her business from 3 employees to 12 in one year.



Impact Report 2025

23

New business created

42

Start-up and early stage businesses

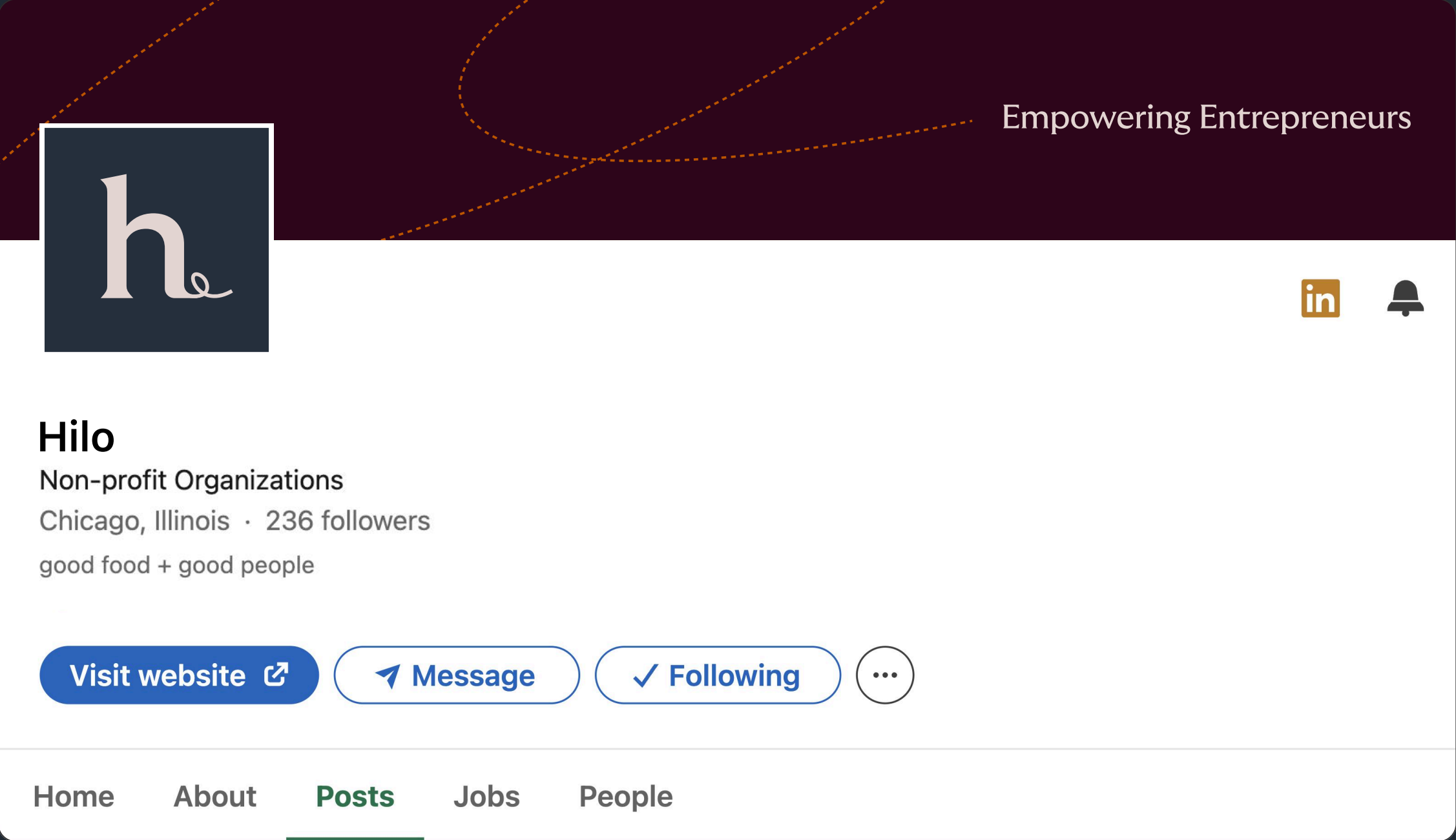
39

New jobs created

Hilo Brand Guidelines

31

LinkedIn Banner and Avatar



Instagram story



Swag and events



Contact

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